

1. DeepSeek V4 Pro 0813 (on OpenRouter)

Source: Simon Willison's Weblog | Published: 2026-08-12T23:59:23+00:00

Link: <https://simonwillison.net/2026/Aug/12/deepseek-v4-pro-0813/>

DeepSeek V4 Pro 0813 (on OpenRouter) The latest DeepSeek Pro model is now available, via API only. I had to link to OpenRouter because DeepSeek don't have any obvious announcement page for their new model. I haven't been able to confirm if they plan to release the open weights, but given the weights are available for both April's deepseek-ai/DeepSeek-V4-Pro and July's deepseek-ai/DeepSeek-V4-Flash-0731 it seems likely. Interestingly I got very different looking pelicans for the three different reasoning levels of low, medium, and high. I've not noticed this kind of difference from any other model: Low: Medium: High: In terms of benchmarks... as far as I can tell those were released to the Official DeepSeek WeChat Group, then copied and pasted into a post on Reddit which was deleted by the moderators for being "low-effort", then copied into this ASCII-art table on Hacker News . Tags: ai , generative-ai , llms , pelican-riding-a-bicycle , deepseek , llm-release , ai-in-china

2. alchemy-utils 0.1a0

Source: Simon Willison's Weblog | Published: 2026-08-12T19:51:30+00:00

Link: <https://simonwillison.net/2026/Aug/12/alchemy-utils/>

Release: alchemy-utils 0.1a0 I've long pondered what a database agnostic version of my sqlite-utils Python library and CLI utility might look like. This morning (literally a shower project) I tasked Codex and GPT-5.6 Sol Ultra with building a prototype: Do a research spike to see what it would take to build a library with the same core API as SQLite-utils - in particular the insert and upsert and insert_all and upsert_all and create and update methods, and the table introspection stuff - but backed by SQLAlchemy so it works for multiple database engines Test against PostgreSQL and SQLite and duckdb Use ~/dev/sqlite-utils for reference Create a git repo for this and commit and early and often - use uv init to start the project - use red/green TDD and pytest, see ~/dev/django-sql-dashboard for one idea as to how the PostgreSQL tests could work It took very few follow-up prompts to produce this project in a state good enough to release as an alpha. Here's a one-liner I can use to list the rows in a table in my local PostgreSQL copy of my blog's database: uvx --with 'alchemy-utils[postgresql]' alchemy-utils rows 'postgresql+psycopg://simon@localhost:5432/simonwillisonblog' redirects_r...

3. Quoting Florian Herrengt

Source: Simon Willison's Weblog | Published: 2026-08-12T15:08:47+00:00

Link: <https://simonwillison.net/2026/Aug/12/florian-herrengt/>

But then users start to report a weird bug. It's the 4th time your team has been trying to fix it. I mean... asking AI to fix it. Unfortunately, it seems like not even Fable can figure it out. You go talk to the person who worked on this feature. "So where does the data come from?" "Hmm... actually I don't know. Let me ask Claude." You sit next to each other watching an endless wall of text appear on the screen. Neither of you has any idea whether any of it is true but Claude seems very confident. [...] This project has become so convoluted, with so many layers and services, that no one on your team could possibly start to understand what's going on. ? Florian Herrengt , AI is removing the middle class of software engineering Tags: ai-misuse , cognitive-debt , generative-ai , ai , llms , ai-assisted-programming

4. Where Did the Productivity Gains Go?

Source: Software and Tech stories from an Insider - iDiallo.com | Published: Wed, 12 Aug 2026 12:00:00 GMT

Link: <https://idiallo.com/blog/where-did-the-productivity-gains-go>

There is a machine called Productivity, and on this machine there is a knob and a button. The knob increases productivity, and the button is labeled "reset." My job was data entry at a non-profit. It was my first job in the US where I didn't have to lift heavy objects. My main

task was entering collected donations into a database. The data source was email attachments, which came in various formats. Excel files, Word files, and some directly embedded in the email body. The database itself was FileMaker Pro. Every part of the process was wasteful. To receive the emails in the first place, I had to call the person who collected the donation, argue with them, and guide them through the process of emailing me the information. The donations were collected at events, and the data was often just handwritten on a note. Once I got the email, I would extract the content from the attachment and organize it into an Excel file. Then I would manually enter it into the FileMaker database, one row at a time. In a full workday, I could process no more than a dozen entries. So I decided to improve the process. I started from the end. Entering data into the database was error-prone. I had to enter t...

5. The little-known winstart.bat batch file

Source: The Old New Thing | Published: Tue, 11 Aug 2026 14:00:00 +0000

Link: <https://devblogs.microsoft.com/oldnewthing/20260811-00/?p=112605>

It had been there long before Windows 95, but nobody remembered. The post The little-known winstart.bat batch file appeared first on The Old New Thing .

6. Google Design Pisses Its Pants on Twitter/X

Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-08-13T01:03:45Z

Link: <https://x.com/googledesign/status/2087195277094695096>

A few years ago I'd have looked at this post and maybe leaned toward the idea that a precocious 8th grader somewhere hacked into the @GoogleDesign Twitter account and tried to pass off their little to-do app as having come from Google's design team. But this is apparently real. I almost hope it's AI slop and that there aren't any human designers there who think anything in this app has appropriate proportions or is aesthetically pleasing. (Here's an XCancel link for the x.com averse. You can just change any x.com/* URL to xcancel.com/*. But, alas, the XCancel mirror of the original tweet loses the animation showing the UI in motion.) ?

7. Joanna Stern on the Pixel 11 ?HiLight? Notification Light

Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-08-12T21:23:30Z

Link: https://thenewthings.com/p/the-new-pixel-feature-i-want-on-my-iphone?gift_content=e9bf3ebd-db33-4ee5-91b0-84d7acac3263

Joanna Stern, writing The New Thing (gift link): I used to love the blinking notification light on my BlackBerry, and later my Droid 2. It was a simple way to know I had a message without actually looking at my messages. Then BlackBerry let you customize the color, and it was a rainbow dream. Google's HiLight takes it a step further by letting you assign different colors to VIP contacts. So when your phone is face down, you can tell who's trying to reach you without picking it up. It looks cool. The big bummer? At launch, it only works for phone calls. Google told me it's ?continuing to invest in this technology? and that messaging notifications are coming. Still, it's odd they aren't there at launch, especially since Google found plenty of colors for Gemini. The ring changes hue depending on whether the AI is listening, thinking or responding. I have no interest in this because a few years ago I stopped ever putting my iPhone on any surface face down. I don't use a case, so setting the phone face down is a good way to pick up scratches. I stopped doing that, ever, and now I've got a nearly year-old iPhone 17 Pro that seemingly doesn't have even a micro abrasion on the display gla...

8. Google Introduces ?Camera Looks? With Pixel 11 Phones

Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-08-12T20:58:15Z

Link:

<https://www.theverge.com/tech/978084/google-camera-looks-interview-computational-photography>

David Imel, The Verge: But in our current moment, the photos people are drawn to are not flawless ? and that's created a real problem for the people making smartphone cameras. ?The gap between what two random people want from their camera is growing dramatically,? says Isaac Reynolds, who leads the Pixel camera team at Google. Some people want a perfectly optimized photo, Reynolds says. ?But there's a growing number of people who want something that they feel

is more authentic or traditional, by their definition.? That?s what Reynolds and the Pixel team are setting out to solve with Camera Looks, a total rethink of how the camera captures and styles an image on the Pixel 11 series. The phones include a new suite of processing tools aimed at giving people much more control over the camera?s output. At first glance, they look a lot like filters, with names like Black Tie, Classic, and most strikingly, Digi, in reference to the growing trend of buying cheap digital cameras from the early aughts. But unlike a filter, which generally applies editing tweaks after the processing happens, Camera Looks is changing how image data is processed at the sensor level. This sounds a lot like Appl...

9. Cryptic but consistent

Source: John D. Cook | Published: Wed, 12 Aug 2026 13:17:03 +0000

Link: <https://www.johndcook.com/blog/2026/08/12/cryptic-but-consistent/>

Suppose you?ve never worked at the command line and you?re reading a book about the bash shell. You read that !\$ is a shortcut to refer to the last word of the previous command. That little fact will almost certainly not stick in your head for a couple reasons. First, you probably see no need [?] The post Cryptic but consistent first appeared on John D. Cook .

10. Books I Enjoyed In 2026H1

Source: Fernando Borretti | Published: Wed, 12 Aug 2026 00:00:00 +0000

Link: <https://borretti.me/article/books-i-enjoyed-in-2026-h1>

A list.

11. Card Sharks

Source: Tedium: The Dull Side of the Internet. | Published: 2026-08-12T18:27:39Z

Link: <https://feed.tedium.co/link/15204/17416577/greeting-cards-care-bears-cartoons-history>

The 1980s proved surprisingly fruitful for licensed greeting card mascots. It turns out American Greetings understood the Marvel playbook before Marvel did.

12. Weekly Update 516: Live From Vietnam

Source: Troy Hunt | Published: Wed, 12 Aug 2026 08:16:15 GMT

Link: <https://www.troyhunt.com/weekly-update-516/>

A little wind noise, a little connectivity flakiness, and a little lip-sync issues from YouTube, but look at that view! ? Back to business, it's the Brinks Home FAQ I found most interesting this week. I mean, how do you write your own FAQ then fail to

13. Pluralistic: Model collapse (12 Aug 2026)

Source: Pluralistic: Daily links from Cory Doctorow | Published: Wed, 12 Aug 2026 08:55:27 +0000

Link: <https://pluralistic.net/2026/08/12/insurance-value-of-biodiversity/>

Today's links Model collapse: Living in a world that's trained on itself. Hey look at this: Delights to delectate. Object permanence: Wired v Dutch hackers; NYT v DMCA; Hair gel terrorist threat does not exist; AT&T merger is a screwjob; Smart cities are stupid; RIP Reaganomics. Upcoming appearances: Edinburgh, Sydney, Melbourne, Brighton, London, South Bend. Recent appearances: Where I've been. Latest books: You keep readin' em, I'll keep writin' 'em. Upcoming books: Like I said, I'll keep writin' 'em. Colophon: All the rest. Model collapse (permalink) One of my favorite rhetorical and analytical moves is joining things together (showing that two different, seemingly unrelated ideas are aspects of the same phenomenon) and taking them apart (resolving a paradox by demonstrating that what appears to be one, contradictory thing is actually two different things that have been lumped together). "Taking things apart" is a very useful framework for understanding AI. How do we resolve the (seeming) paradox that some skilled workers report wonderful results from their work with AI, while others are full of dire warnings about the lurking defects in their AI-assisted outputs? Simple: the f...

14. OTel Isn't Going Well (And I Made A Spreadsheet About It)

Source: matduggan.com | Published: Wed, 12 Aug 2026 11:14:11 GMT

Link: <https://matduggan.com/otel-isnt-going-well-and-i-made-a-spreadsheet-about-it/>

For years now one of the most reliable complaints I hear when I try to drag a team off their vendor specific SDK and onto OpenTelemetry is some variation of: "why does it seem like this isn't done yet?" Vendor SDKs for observability are, to put